2. The term (caretaker government) has come to be used in common parlance to describe the status of a council of ministers that has resigned on having lost the confidence of the Lok Sabha or otherwise but is asked by the President to continue till alternative arrangements are made. If an alternative government cannot be formed immediately and general elections have to be held, the outgoing council of ministers may have to hold charge till the conclusion of elections and formation of new government[7].

 **Limited Role**

Unlike a regular government, a caretaker government is meant for only managing the routine activities of the government. Hence, it is not expected to make any significant policy decisions or initiate new measures and schemes except those relating to national security or national interest.

The following comments and observations highlight the limited role of a caretaker government in the governance of the country:

1. The Tarkunde Committee (1974–75) recommended that a caretaker government should not: (i) initiate and announce new policies, (ii) promise or start new projects, (iii) grant allowances or loans, salary increases, and (iv) hold official functions attended by ministers[8].

2. In August 1979, the then President N. Sanjeeva Reddy, while dissolving the Lok Sabha, issued a communique stating that the President had consultations with the Prime Minister and some of his cabinet colleagues who assured that:

(i) Elections will be peaceful, free and fair. The revision of the electoral rolls will begin immediately and the election time-table will commence in November 1979 and will be completed by December 1979.

(ii) The Government will not take decisions during this period which set new policies or involve new spending of a significant order or constitute measures of administrative or executive decisions. However, work of an urgent nature involving the national interest will not be held up.

3. The Calcutta High Court in a judgement delivered in December 1979 observed that there is no mention of a caretaker government as such in our constitution, but such an extraordinary situation calls for a caretaker government and, therefore, the Prime Minister and the Council of Ministers can, in such a situation only carry on day-to-day administration in office, which are necessary for carrying on for the sake of making an alternative arrangement.

4. The caretaker Prime Ministers are constrained for two reasons: first, the normal channel of accountability through Parliament does not exist; second, the government does not abuse its position to gain electoral advantage[9].

Table 20.1 Articles Related to Prime Minister at a Glance

Article No.	Subject Matter
74.	Council of Ministers to aid and advise President